



Numbers don't lie: As of January 27, Sachin has 904 raid points to his name (956 overall), out of which 223 have come from do-or-die raids. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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This was around the same time that names like Pawan Sehrawat and Rohit Gulia were still fresh-faced talents taking their time to settle. Not Sachin, though. He wasted no time in accumulating 173 points in 24 games, playing a key role in the side making the final of that edition.

His performances sealed his retention for the next season, and Sachin came through once more, scoring 204 points (190 of those in raiding) and seeing the side through to its second consecutive summit clash. Gujarat lost both of those title bouts, but Sachin was the silver lining, scoring resilient Super 10s on both occasions.

The seventh season of PKL was underwhelming for the raider, who could accrue only 85 points.

Testing times

Eventually, he moved from Gujarat to Patna, and it was business as usual as he managed 183 points playing in a three-pronged raiding unit and played his third final in four seasons.

While much had changed for the man, his bad luck in finals continued as Patna finished second best to Dabang Delhi by the barest of margins — a solitary point.

"This has happened to me three times, where I've missed out on the trophy after getting so close," Sachin says.

While the 24-year-old has seen the euphoric highs of dominant campaigns, he has also dealt with the difficulties of poor collective form. Particularly in PKL 9, when Patna could not replicate its command on the mat from the previous edition and finished 10th in the standings.

Rain or shine, it didn't matter. Sachin's consistency endured, with the raider registering 179 points in the season.

It's not so much the hoard of points he has as how those points have come. As of January 27, Sachin has 904 raid points (956 overall), out of which 223 have come from do-or-die raids.

His effectiveness in these crunch raids, where the player has to come back with either a bonus or a touch, has set him apart from the more widely followed stars of the league.

"My life's very first raid in PKL was a do-or-die raid. I still remember that match against Dabang Delhi.

"I came back with points when I was sent early on for do-or-die raids, and success meant I got more opportunities. It has now become

something I am associated with," Sachin explains.

Becoming Sachin

Sachin's unassuming nature means that the celebrity status that often gets accorded to his peers slips past him. It doesn't bother the Patna raider. For him, the raucous welcome he gets when he heads home is the biggest ego boost of all.

"My brother and I were, for a long time, the only kabaddi players from our village. That has changed now. I love going back home. So many people come up to me; they are either players or fans. Now 50-60 kids have taken up the game after seeing me on TV and what I do.

"So I spend time sharing what I know with them. During the off-season, when I am home, I practise with them, and that motivates them a lot," Sachin says.

An Asian Games gold, national recognition, and a formidable record in the best league in the sport — life's not too shabby for Sachin.

However, bringing back a PKL champion's medal and cheque to parents who worried about the comforts a life in sports could give him would be a great way to let life come full circle.